

SEO CHECKLIST

AI SEO Checklist 2026

The complete step-by-step SEO checklist for AI-assisted content — from keyword research to ranking.

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How to Use This Checklist

This checklist covers every SEO action you need to take before, during, and after publishing content. Work through it in order. The items marked [CRITICAL] have the biggest impact on rankings — do not skip them.

■ Pro Tip

Google does not penalize AI-written content. It penalizes low-quality, unhelpful content. AI-written content that is accurate, detailed, and genuinely useful ranks just as well as human-written content — and often better because it is more consistent.

1. Keyword Research

■ Identify your primary keyword — the exact phrase your ideal reader types into Google

Use Google Search, Ahrefs, Semrush, or Ubersuggest to find it. Look for keywords with 500-10,000 monthly searches and low-to-medium competition.

■ Check the search intent — what does the searcher actually want?

Informational (how to, what is), Commercial (best, review, vs), Transactional (buy, price), Navigational (specific brand). Your content must match the intent exactly.

■ Find 5-10 secondary keywords (related terms and questions)

These are variations and related topics you should cover in the article. Include them naturally throughout the content.

■ Analyze the top 3 results for your keyword

Note their word count, structure, headings, and what they cover. Your content must be better — more detailed, more current, more useful.

■ Check "People Also Ask" in Google

These questions reveal exactly what readers want to know. Answer them in your article — this is how you get featured snippets.

2. Before You Write

■ Create a content brief

Document: primary keyword, secondary keywords, target word count, main sections to cover, questions to answer, competing articles to beat.

■ Determine the ideal format for the content

List post, how-to guide, comparison article, review, or news article. The format should match what Google is already ranking for that keyword.

■ Set your target word count based on competitors

Count the words of the top 3 ranking articles. Match or exceed the average. Do not pad — every sentence should add value.

■ Plan your header structure (H1, H2, H3)

Include your primary keyword in the H1. Include related keywords in H2 headings. H3s are for subsections — use them to organize complex information.

3. On-Page SEO

■ Title tag — 50-60 characters, primary keyword near the start

Example: "10 Best AI Writing Tools in 2026 (Tested & Ranked)" — keyword first, year for freshness, brackets for specificity.

■ Meta description — 150-160 characters, includes keyword, has a call to action

Example: "Looking for the best AI writing tools? I tested 30+ options and ranked the top 10 for 2026. See which ones are worth your time."

■ H1 heading — matches or closely mirrors the title tag, includes primary keyword

The H1 is the most important on-page SEO element after the title. It should appear exactly once and contain your primary keyword.

■ URL slug — short, keyword-focused, no stop words

Good: /best-ai-writing-tools — Bad: /the-10-best-ai-writing-tools-you-should-use-in-2026

■ First paragraph — mention primary keyword within the first 100 words

Google gives extra weight to keywords that appear early in the content. Include your keyword naturally in the opening paragraph.

■ Secondary keywords — distributed naturally throughout the content

Do not stuff keywords. Include them where they make sense. A good rule: if it reads awkwardly, remove it.

■ Internal links — link to 3-5 related pages on your site

Internal links help Google understand your site structure and pass authority between pages. Always link to relevant content, never to irrelevant pages.

■ External links — link to 2-3 authoritative sources

Citing credible sources (studies, official sites, authoritative blogs) increases your content's credibility with both Google and readers.

4. Content Quality

■ Answer the search query completely and clearly in the first 200 words

Do not bury the answer. Readers and Google both want to know immediately that this page has what they are looking for.

■ Cover all subtopics that searchers expect to find

Look at the "People Also Ask" section and the subheadings of top-ranking articles. If they cover it, you should cover it too — and better.

■ Use short paragraphs (2-4 sentences maximum)

Long paragraphs are abandoned. Short paragraphs are read. This is especially important for mobile readers.

■ Include a comparison table or summary table

Tables dramatically increase time-on-page and are frequently used in featured snippets. Include one for any comparison or list content.

■ Add a FAQ section at the end

Answer 4-6 common questions about your topic. Use FAQPage schema markup. This can earn you featured snippets and People Also Ask placements.

■ Write a clear conclusion with next steps

Tell the reader what to do next. Link to a related article, suggest a tool to try, or recommend a specific action. Never just stop writing.

5. Images & Media

■ Add alt text to every image — descriptive, includes keyword where natural

Example alt text: "Screenshot of ChatGPT writing a blog post — best AI writing tool 2026"

■ Compress all images before uploading

Use TinyPNG or Squoosh.app. Images should be under 100KB for photos, under 30KB for illustrations. Page speed is a ranking factor.

■ Use descriptive file names for images

Good: chatgpt-ai-writing-tool.jpg — Bad: IMG_4829.jpg

■ Include at least one original image or screenshot

Original images that cannot be found elsewhere increase your content's uniqueness score and are more likely to earn backlinks.

6. Technical SEO

■ Page loads in under 3 seconds on mobile

Test at PageSpeed Insights (pagespeed.web.dev). Fix any issues flagged as "Opportunities." Page speed is a confirmed Google ranking factor.

■ Page is mobile-responsive

Over 60% of searches happen on mobile. Test every page on a real phone, not just a browser emulator.

■ Add schema markup appropriate to your content type

Article schema for blog posts. HowTo schema for guides. FAQ schema for FAQ sections. Recipe schema for recipes. Schema markup helps Google understand your content.

■ Canonical URL is set correctly

Every page should have a canonical URL to prevent duplicate content issues, especially on pages that can be accessed via multiple URLs.

■ Sitemap is submitted to Google Search Console

Submit your sitemap at search.google.com/search-console. Google will crawl and index your new content faster.

■ No broken links on the page

Check for broken links before publishing. Use a browser extension like Check My Links or the broken links report in Google Search Console.

7. After Publishing

■ Submit the URL to Google Search Console for indexing

Go to Search Console, paste the URL in the top bar, click "Request Indexing." This tells Google to crawl your new page immediately instead of waiting days or weeks.

■ Share on social media channels

Post to your social accounts on the day of publishing. Social signals are not a direct ranking factor but they drive traffic that helps Google evaluate content quality.

■ Monitor rankings weekly for the first month

Use Google Search Console to track impressions and clicks. Most pages need 3-6 months to reach their peak ranking.

■ Update the content every 6-12 months

Google rewards fresh content. Set a reminder to review and update your top-performing articles. Even small updates (adding new information, updating statistics) can boost rankings.

■ Build at least 3 backlinks to important new pages

Backlinks remain the most important ranking factor. Share in relevant communities, reach out to sites that link to similar content, or create content so good it earns links naturally.

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